



Preliminary investigation update

Grounding on Boolarong Bank, Weerona Channel, Kanooka Heads -
Preliminary investigation update

Drafted 30/09/2026

INVESTIGATION WORKFLOW SUITE

Contents

Summary 3

What we know..... 4

What we are looking at..... 5

Containment and next steps..... 6

 Interim action and containment..... 6

 Next steps..... 6

 Distribution 6

Summary

On 07/07/2026 the passenger ferry MV Tarrakin Star, carrying 38 passengers, a master, a deckhand and a kiosk attendant on service TF18, grounded on Boolarong Bank, outside the dredged Weerona Channel at Kanooka Heads, at 18:12 in darkness. No one was seriously injured: one passenger reported a grazed shin, and two were treated at the wharf for distress. The vessel had substantial damage to its starboard hull, propeller, shaft, rudder and skeg, including a split that let water into one void space. The channel was closed to commercial traffic for 19 hours. The investigation is examining four matters: the freezing of the vessel's chart plotter during the transit, the arrangements for night operations on the route, the visibility of the No. 4 beacon, and how the channel's aids to navigation are managed. The vessel has been withdrawn from service.

What we know

On 07/07/2026 the MV Tarrakin Star, a 24.4 m aluminium catamaran ferry certificated for 96 passengers, operated TF18, the day's last service from Muntari Island to Kanooka Heads. It carried 38 passengers, a master, a deckhand and a kiosk attendant. Times are local.

The master took over the vessel at the town wharf at about 13:05. The outgoing master told him that the chart plotter (the electronic chart display) had frozen twice that morning and had recovered by itself each time. Neither master entered this in the defect book.

TF18 departed at 17:35. Civil twilight had ended at 17:29, so the channel transit was in full darkness. The vessel entered the Weerona Channel from the north at about 18:04. At 18:05:30 it was on the charted centreline abeam the No. 2 beacon at 8.4 knots. By then the deckhand had left the bridge to collect fares.

At 18:07:06 the plotter froze and did not recover. The master left the throttles unchanged and looked for the No. 4 beacon on the western side of the channel. He sighted it at 18:10:02, 91 seconds after he began looking. Meanwhile, the heading increased from 195 to 200 degrees over about a minute and was held. The vessel crossed the western edge of the dredged channel at about 18:09 and was over Boolarong Bank by about 18:11. Engine and steering data show no fault or alarm during the transit.

The echo sounder's shallow alarm, set at 0.9 m under the keel, sounded at 18:11:48, and both throttles went astern four seconds later. At 18:12:04 the vessel struck the bank at 6.8 knots, 74 m west of the charted centreline and 54 m outside the dredged channel. It stopped within 11 m, heeled 4 degrees to starboard, on a falling tide.

The master stopped both engines and did not attempt to refloat. At 18:13:04 he made a pan pan (urgency) call to Kanooka Heads Port Control on VHF channel 16. All passengers were in lifejackets by about 18:22. Issue was slower in the forward saloon, where the locker is behind the kiosk counter. Water in the No. 2 starboard void rose from approximately 75 mm at 18:16 to approximately 260 mm by 00:20. The port workboat came alongside at 18:41, and the last passenger was ashore at 19:26.

No one was seriously injured. One passenger reported a grazed shin, and two were treated at the wharf for distress. Damage was to the starboard side:

- bottom plating set up over 4.1 m, with a 180 mm split
- propeller and shaft bent
- rudder stock distorted
- skeg torn away.

The vessel refloated at 00:20 on 08/07/2026 and was withdrawn from service. The Weerona Channel was closed to commercial traffic for 19 hours.

What we are looking at

1. **The chart plotter and how its fault was reported.** The investigation is examining why the plotter display froze. Its event log records the same fault twice that morning. A 46 hour bench test did not reproduce it, and a manufacturer's firmware update issued in 11/2024 had not been applied to the unit. Also being examined is how defects are passed between masters at handover and entered in the defect book.
2. **The move of TF18 into darkness.** The winter timetable moved TF18 from 16:15 to 17:35. The investigation is examining how that change was assessed against the route risk assessment RRA-07, which restricts the channel to daylight transits, and what the operator's passage plan provides for a night transit or loss of the plotter.
3. **How the transit was conducted after the plotter froze.** This includes the master's options, the speed held, the absence of a lookout on the bridge, and the echo sounder's shallow alarm setting, unchanged since 2019.
4. **The visibility of the No. 4 beacon.** Matters being examined are:
 - its conversion to a solar lantern with a lower rated range
 - mangrove growth on Weerona Islet between the beacon and the northern approach
 - how the beacon is inspected and maintained
 - the requirements for aids to navigation on this channel.
5. **Crew rostering and lifejacket access.** Two further matters are being examined separately: the winter roster, which places the last darkness transit at the end of a split duty; and access to the forward saloon lifejacket locker, which sits behind a kiosk counter fitted in a 2019 refit. The same counter is fitted to the operator's two other 24 m vessels.
6. **New foreshore floodlighting.** Whether new floodlighting at the boat ramp, behind the beacon as seen from the channel, affected the master's ability to see it could not be resolved on the available evidence and remains open.

Containment and next steps

Interim action and containment

- **Evening services suspended.** On 08/07/2026, the day after the grounding, the General Manager Operations suspended the evening Muntari services. Whether the suspension remains in place, and on what terms, is [NOT ESTABLISHED: current status of the suspension of evening Muntari services].
- **Vessel withdrawn.** The MV Tarrakin Star has been out of service since it refloated.
- **No. 4 beacon.** The investigation has told the Port Authority and the operator what it has found about the beacon: it is screened from the northern approach, and its range fell after the solar conversion. Any action either body has taken in response is [NOT ESTABLISHED: response of the Port Authority and the operator].
- **Forward saloon lifejacket locker.** The question of whether the same kiosk counter affects the operator's two other 24 m vessels is with the operator and the state regulator.

No other interim safety action has been recorded.

Next steps

The investigation is now:

- waiting for the operator's and the state regulator's answers on lifejacket access across the fleet
- examining the foreshore floodlighting question, which remains open
- seeking a formal account from the Operations Manager, whose account so far was given verbally
- having the draft reviewed by someone outside the investigation
- giving the people and organisations it covers the chance to correct matters of fact
- confirming who owns each safety action and when it is due.

The expected date for the final report is [NOT ESTABLISHED: timeframe for the final report].

Distribution

Title	Name
General Manager Operations	H. Vardon
Safety Manager	P. Nandasiri
Operations Manager	C. Bickerton
Harbour Master, Kanooka Heads	L. Truscott
Aids to Navigation Officer, Kanooka Shire Council	E. Maguire